Arab Mixed Farming

It is impossible to make a quantitative projection of the trend of employment in Arab Fellah agriculture during the coming decade even when surrounded by the broad qualifications and reservations which we have found necessary in the case of Jewish "mixed" farming. Too little is known of the economics of Fellah farming to justify more than the broadest generalizations. As indicated above (page 220), even the present employment in Arab farming is known only subject to a wide area of uncertainty.

In the 1930's the drift away from agriculture was inhibited by the expansion of citriculture. If our views of the outlook for citrus and other export crops are approximately correct, these agricultural branches will not account for a larger share of Arab employment in the next decade than they did in the 1930's. With the greater non-agricultural opportunities created by large-scale Jewish immigration, the Arab trend away from farm occupations will probably be accentuated. That is also the course which is suggested by a policy directed towards raising Arab incomes -- both on the farm and elsewhere.

However, the Arab labor force is clearly sufficiently elastic so that increased employment in industry, construction, etc. does not necessarily mean decreased employment in agriculture. The Fellah farm community contains a large reservoir of underemployment. Mr. G. E. Wood's investigations suggest that from 1939 to 1942 that reservoir was drawn upon so heavily as to raise the ratio of total gainful employment in the non-Jewish population from about 32 percent to about 38 percent. During these years, according to his studies, non-Jewish non-farm employment more than doubled, while non-Jewish agricultural employment remained approximately constant at roughly 248,000 persons (full-time equivalent).

Even without the extraordinary stimuli of wartime, the Fellaheen will be able both to supply more labor to urban occupations and to increase their agricultural output. Today a full working year for the Fellah is 250 days; his farm organization does not permit more. Today also the tempo of his labor is low, much lower than can reasonably be attributed to climate alone.